brigade) had been ferried across the Lohit on boats that had been brought up from Rima.

15-16 NOVEMBER: THE CHINESE COUNTER-ATTACK

The terrain in Walong had resulted in defences that were isolated posts or strongholds. These were not mutually supportive of each other, resulting in a situation where each commanding officer had to fight his own independent battle. By the time HQ 11 Infantry Brigade came into play, the original defence plans had already been unbalanced by the forward move and then withdrawal of 6 Kumaon to Kibithu and back.

The influx of the new battalion (4 Sikh) was mired in confusion with two companies initially being airlifted to Along instead. Part of 2/8 GR was first brought to Walong, then de-inducted shortly thereafter. 3/3 GR first marched in from Hayuliang, was turned around and sent back, then ordered back yet again. 4 Dogra was then flown in, the Otters flying almost fifty sorties for their induction. In all this upheaval, it is important to note that, on an average, one infantry battalion requires close to 10 tons of supplies a day. Wind conditions in the Walong Valley generally restricted the Otter operations to three to four hours a day. The airlift capacity of the five Mi-4 helicopters allotted to this sector and the air drops by DC-3 Dakotas were not enough to meet the fresh requirements, so the troops were surviving on the existing stockpile, which was meagre to start with. As a result, ammunition in particular was in short supply, especially for the artillery.

The unrealistic timeline given to the Kumaonis to force the Chinese out of Yellow and Green Pimple once again resulted in the destabilizing of the Walong defences. Two battalions out of the four available (6 Kumaon and 4 Dogra) were pinned down at or committed to Trijunction. In what must also be a first of sorts in modern warfare, the Walong garrison also had to deal with the presence of the corps commander and the GOC of the division who spent a lot of time sitting in the Brigade HQ, thereby limiting their own overview of the unfolding battle. Quite simply the Chinese could now dictate the course of the battle.

Having withstood the determined assault by 6 Kumaon and successfully pushed them back onto the Trijunction, the Chinese launched their counter-attack at 4.30 a.m. With just one platoon from Charlie Company at his disposal, Bhatia reinforced Trijunction’s defences with the Battalion HQ personnel along with the Medical Platoon. As the survivors of the ill-fated